

The Employee Handbook

A Guide to People Policies and Process

COGNITIVZEN TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED

Version 1.0

Document History

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1. A WELCOME NOTE

Dear Mr./Ms. Chitrakavi Lakshmi Anuhya

Welcome to CognitivZen! We are delighted to have you join our team of talented professionals. As you embark on this new chapter of your career with us, we want to extend a warm welcome and express our sincere appreciation for choosing to be a part of our organization.

At CognitivZen, we are committed to fostering an environment of continuous learning, growth and excellence. We believe that each member of our team brings unique skills, perspectives and experiences that contribute to our collective success. As you settle into your role, we encourage you to embrace new challenges, see opportunities for growth and strive for excellence in everything you do.

This employee handbook serves as a valuable resource to help you navigate our company policies, procedures and expectations. We encourage you to familiarize yourself with its contents and refer to it as needed throughout your employment journey. Our goal is to provide you with the support, resources and tools you need to succeed and thrive in your role, bringing in the ultimate CognitivZen's Customer delight.

As you embark on this exciting journey with us, remember that your contributions are integral to our success. We believe in recognizing – rewarding hard work, dedication-innovation and we are committed to creating a work environment where you can reach your full potential.

I once again, welcome you to the CognitivZen team! We look forward to working alongside you and supporting you as you grow and excel in your career.

Best regards,



SYAMA S PEELA
CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER
COGNITIVZEN TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED

2. INTRODUCTION OF THE HANDBOOK

This handbook has been carefully crafted to provide you with important information about our company policies, procedures, benefits and expectations. We encourage you to read through this document thoroughly and refer to it whenever you have questions about your employment with us.

At CognitivZen, we believe that our employees are our most valuable asset. We are committed to creating an inclusive, supportive and respectful work environment where everyone can thrive and reach their full potential.

In this book, you will find detailed guidelines on topics ranging from company's Mission, Vision and Values which serve as the foundation of our culture to equal employment opportunity and workplace safety.

We understand that our success as a company depends on the collective efforts of our talented and dedicated team members. As you take this journey with us, we encourage you to embrace our company values, collaborate with your colleagues and contribute your unique skills and perspectives to help us achieve our goals.

Should you have any questions or need further classifications, please don't hesitate to reach out to your manager or the Human Resource Department for assistance at hr@cognitivzen.com and admin@cognitivzen.com for HR and Admin related issues/queries respectively.

All previously issued handbooks are superseded. The Company reserves the right to revise, delete or add to all policies, procedures, work rules or benefits stated in this handbook. All such revisions, deletions or additions may be made at any time with or without notice.

3. ABOUT THE COMPANY

3.1 Company Overview

Company Introduction

CognitivZen is a Specialist Software Consulting company established on 12th June 2020, focusing on Outsourced Product Development (OPD), Enterprise Application Development, Digital Transformation, Big Data AI/ML, and Technology/Package Implementation services headquartered in San Jose, CA, USA, and with its offshore center in Hyderabad, India.

Our offerings include technology assessment, architecture, design, development, testing, deployment, and ongoing support. As part of our OPD service, we adopt an on-demand approach to technology delivery, enabling your business to stay nimble and adaptive.

Over the past two decades, CognitivZen has pioneered the use of Enterprise Open-Source Software to deliver robust and scalable solutions that result in quick product rollouts and high ROI's. We have built expertise on Liferay technologies over the past 10 years.

“CognitivZen Technologies Private Limited”



3.2 Mission Statement

At CognitivZen Technologies, we strive to:

- Deliver **world-class digital products** through deep engineering expertise and agile execution.
- Build **long-term partnerships** grounded in transparency, trust, and mutual success.
- Prioritize **customer-centric innovation** that solves real problems and drives tangible outcomes.
- Lead with **integrity and honesty**, ensuring quality, accountability, and clear communication in every engagement.

3.3 Vision Statement

To be the most trusted outsourced product development partner, empowering global enterprises through intelligent, scalable, and transparent software solutions.

3.4 Core Values

At CognitivZen, our 6 core values shape our actions, decisions, and interactions each day. They guide us in delivering results and creating a positive impact on our employees, customers, partners, and communities. These values are fundamental to who we are and what we stand for.

3.4.1. Customer Centricity: We put our clients at the heart of every decision — listening, adapting, and co-creating products that align with their vision and success.

3.4.2. Transparency: We believe in open dialogue, clear commitments, and full visibility across all aspects of delivery and collaboration.

3.4.3. Integrity & Honesty: We do what's right — always. We act ethically, communicate truthfully, and deliver on our promises.

3.4.4. Engineering Excellence: We take pride in building high-performance, scalable products that meet the highest standards of quality and security.

3.4.5. Agility with Ownership: We move fast and responsibly — responding to change while staying accountable to outcomes.

3.4.6. Innovation Culture: We encourage curiosity, embrace change, and constantly seek smarter ways to solve tomorrow's challenges today.

3.5 Management Team

Syama S Peela - **Chairman & CEO**

- 30+ years of IT service industry experience
- Founder of Innominds & Netfish.
- Served in the board of TIE Hyderabad
Angel Investor in a few technology companies.

K. C. Ramakrishna - **CTO**

- Over 20+ years of experience working with FOSS Technologies
- Successful Open-Source project
 - Elasticray, UDAN, Devranker

Pratyush Dash - **Senior Director - Delivery**

- 25+ years of experience in the field of Software development, Product and Program Management.

Murali Krishna Dammalapati - **Vice President - Engineering & Technologies**

- 30+ years of experience as a Principal Technical Architect in Software development and Product Development

4. WORK CULTURE

4.1 Code of Conduct / Ethics

We uphold the highest standards of integrity, professionalism, and ethical behaviour in all aspects of our business operations. Our Code of Conduct serves as a guide for employees to understand the principles and

values that govern our conduct and interactions with colleagues, customers, partners, and the community. By adhering to these principles, we maintain trust, uphold our reputation, and demonstrate our commitment to ethical business practices.

Integrity: We act with honesty, transparency, and ethics in all our actions, choosing what's right even in tough situations.

Respect & Fair Treatment: We treat everyone with dignity and fairness, fostering an inclusive, supportive workplace.

Compliance with Laws and Regulations: We strictly follow all laws, regulations, and internal policies, and report any violations promptly.

Conflict of Interest: We avoid situations that could compromise our judgment and always act in the company's best interest.

Protection of Company Assets: We use company resources responsibly and safeguard intellectual property and confidential information.

Confidentiality: We protect sensitive information and do not share it without proper authorization.

Professional Conduct: We maintain respectful, courteous behavior with all stakeholders.

Reporting Violations: We encourage the reporting of any unethical behavior and ensure proper investigation.

Non-Compliance: Breaches of this Code may result in disciplinary action, including termination.

4.2 Business Ethics

All employees are expected to observe the highest standards of ethical conduct in dealing with both internal and external business relationships in the performance of their jobs. It must be understood that no employee shall do anything illegal in the performance of his/her job, and it is equally important that employees exercise good, ethical and moral judgment at all times. Not only should wrongdoing itself be avoided, but also even the appearance of wrongdoing. In other words, no employee should put himself or herself in a position where someone could question the propriety of the employee's actions from a legal, ethical and/or conflict of interest standpoint.

All employees at CognitivZen must not engage in any activity or maintain any financial interest that might interfere or appear to interfere with the independent exercise of judgment and the performance of responsibilities in the best interests of the Company.

Business Related Meals, Entertainment, and Travel

Employees may provide and accept business meals, entertainment, lodging, and travel, including attendance at sporting or cultural events, as long as it is associated with an occasion at which business is discussed, and is provided as a normal part of business. The value of the activity must be reasonable and permissible under the company's expense account procedures, regardless of whether or not the company is paying for the activity. Employees must obtain prior approval from their supervisor.

Use of Open-Source Code Software

The term "open-source code software" commonly refers to software programs made widely available in source code form for use and modification by contributors under the terms of a license agreement that does not require a fee for the sale, sublicense, or redistribution of the software or derivative works and that does not restrict a licensee from selling or giving away the software as a component of a larger software program or

system license. Any use of such software must be approved by the Legal Department and approved by the customer.

4.3 Disciplinary Policy

Employees shall be subject to disciplinary action if the Company determines that employee's conduct is either counterproductive or not in the best interests of the company. The Company utilizes the following forms of disciplinary action:

1. Verbal discussion and warning.
2. Written warning placed in the employee's file.
3. Suspension without pay; or
4. Termination of Employment

This is not a progressive list of disciplinary actions. The Company may choose any one or more forms of action from this list that the Company determines, is necessary to correct the employee's behavior. This determination will include factors such as the gravity of the infractions, the facts and circumstances surrounding the infractions, and the employee's past work and disciplinary record.

The Company reserves the right to supplement the forms of disciplinary action and to implement remedies not mentioned above. Significant deviations from expected employee behaviour may result in immediate termination of employment and benefits.

4.4 Workplace Safety & Security

Safe Work Environment

CognitivZen is committed to making the work environment safe, secure and healthy for its employees. To help ensure a safe, secure and healthy environment, CognitivZen prohibits certain activities, including but not limited to:

- Threatening or violent behavior or even the suggestion of such behavior, toward others, including co-workers and people outside the Company.
- Possession of firearms, explosives, or other weapons anywhere on Company property or while conducting Company business.
- Willful destruction, misuse or misappropriation of company property or the property of others.

4.5 Anti-Harassment and Anti-Discrimination

At CognitivZen, we are committed to providing a work environment that is free from all forms of harassment and discrimination. We value the dignity and worth of every individual and believe that all employees should be treated with respect and fairness. Harassment and discrimination are strictly prohibited and will not be tolerated under any circumstances.

Definition

Harassment is defined as any unwelcome conduct based on a protected characteristic, including race, colour, religion, sex, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, sexual orientation, gender identity, or any

other characteristic protected by law. Harassment may include, but is not limited to, verbal or physical conduct that creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive work environment.

Prohibited Conduct Examples include, but not limited to:

Making derogatory or offensive comments or jokes related to a person's race, gender, religion, or other protected characteristics.

Displaying or distributing offensive materials, such as posters, emails, or images, that contain discriminatory or harassing content

Engaging in unwelcome physical contact, gestures, or advances of a sexual nature

Retaliating against an individual for reporting harassment or discrimination or participating in an investigation.

Reporting Procedures:

Employees who experience or witness harassment or discrimination are encouraged to report the behaviour promptly to their supervisor, manager, or the Human Resources department. Reports may be made verbally or in writing and should include specific details of the incident(s), including dates, times, witnesses, and any supporting documentation.

Employees who are unsure whether certain behaviour constitutes harassment or discrimination are encouraged to seek guidance from HR or a supervisor.

Confidentiality and non-retaliation:

Reports of harassment or discrimination will be handled with the utmost confidentiality to the extent possible, consistent with the need to investigate and take appropriate action. Employees who report harassment or discrimination or participate in an investigation will not be subject to retaliation or adverse treatment as a result of their report or participation.

Investigation and Resolution:

All reports of harassment or discrimination will be promptly and thoroughly investigated by the Human Resources department or designated individuals. Investigations will be conducted in a fair and impartial manner, and appropriate action will be taken to address and remedy any violations of company policy.

Employees who are found to have engaged in harassment or discrimination may be subject to disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment.

Contact Information:

If you have questions or concerns about harassment or discrimination or need to report an incident, please contact the Human Resources department at hr@cognitivzen.com.

4.6 Fitness for Work / Drug Free Awareness

CognitivZen has an obligation to its employees, customers and the public to ensure reasonable safety in its workplace and to comply with applicable laws. Drug or alcohol use that violates any law is prohibited. Furthermore, any use or abuse of alcohol and drugs in a manner that negatively impacts an employee's work

or the safety of others is also prohibited.

The company specifically prohibits the following acts during business hours, while in the workplace or while conducting Company business.

- Being under the influence of alcohol or illegal drugs.
- The manufacture, distribution, sale or possession or use of “controlled substances” (i.e. illegal or prescription drugs) which is in violation of the law or of legal drugs used in an unlawful or impermissible manner.
- The use of, or being under the influence of, any legally obtained drug in such use or influence may affect the safety of the employee, co-workers, or members of the public.

4.7 Confidentiality and Non-disclosure

1. A non-disclosure agreement (NDA), also known as a confidentiality agreement (CA), confidential disclosure agreement (CDA), proprietary information agreement (PIA), or secrecy agreement (SA), is a legal contract between at least two parties that outlines confidential material, knowledge, or information that the parties wish to share with one another for certain purposes, but wish to restrict access to or by third parties. It is a contract through which the parties agree not to disclose information covered by the agreement.
2. An NDA creates a confidential relationship between the parties to protect any type of confidential and proprietary information or trade secrets. As such, an NDA protects non- public business information.
3. NDAs are commonly signed when two companies, individuals, or other entities (such as partnerships, societies, etc.) are considering doing business and need to understand the processes used in each other's business for the purpose of evaluating the potential business relationship. NDAs can be "mutual", meaning both parties are restricted in their use of the materials provided, or they can restrict the use of material by a single party.
4. During your employment, you will have access to confidential information, including proprietary data, trade secrets, and personal information about the company, its employees, and its clients. You must ensure the confidentiality of this information and prevent any unauthorized use or disclosure.
5. You agree to receive and maintain the confidentiality of all confidential information provided by the company or its affiliates or clients. You must prevent any unauthorized use or disclosure of this information.
6. You agree to:
 - a) Use confidential information only for the purpose for which it was shared.
 - b) Obtain written consent before disclosing any confidential information to third parties.
 - c) Treat confidential information with the same care as your own.
 - d) Prevent unauthorized use or disclosure of confidential information.
 - e) Only copy or reproduce confidential information as necessary.
 - f) Not share confidential information with competitors or third parties.
 - g) Not use confidential information for personal gain or to harm the company.
 - h) Not claim ownership of any confidential information.
 - i) Not use confidential information in any manner that may harm the company or its affiliates.
7. All confidential information remains the property of the company. No license or rights to confidential information are granted.
8. You are not obligated to maintain the confidentiality of confidential information if it:
 - a) Was in your possession before receiving it from the company.
 - b) Becomes public knowledge through no fault of yours.

- c) Is received from a third party without a duty of confidentiality.
9. If you receive a court order requiring disclosure of confidential information, you must notify the company and cooperate with any legal proceedings.
 10. Upon termination of your employment, you must return or destroy any confidential information in your possession.
 11. You must not disclose confidential information to anyone unless necessary for your job or required by law.
 12. Breach of confidentiality may result in disciplinary action, including termination of employment.
 13. You must maintain confidentiality of price-sensitive information and comply with trading restrictions during your employment.
 14. All employees must sign an NDA or NDA – like agreement with the employer. In fact, some employment agreements will include a clause restricting employees' use and dissemination of confidential company-owned information.

5. COMPANY POLICIES

5.1 Equal Employment Opportunity

Diversity of employees is not only legally and morally important, but it is also a source of strength for any company. CognitivZen has been and will continue to be strongly committed to recruiting, hiring, developing, compensating and promoting the best-qualified individuals for positions at all levels within the Company. These goals may only be achieved if we can obtain, enhance and utilize the abilities of superior candidates. We will therefore maintain our unequivocal commitment to and support equal employment opportunity for all individuals, free from discrimination based in characteristics protected by law such as race, religion, age, national origin or other characteristics protected by law.

All employment practices, including advertising, recruiting, hiring, promoting, Company sponsored training, transfer, layoff, return from layoff, termination, compensation and benefits, and social or recreational programs are determined on the basis of individual merit, free from prohibited discrimination or harassment.

Every employee and manager are responsible to ensure that the spirit and intent of the Company's goals and Equal Employment Opportunity policies are achieved. Likewise, employees have the responsibility to treat co-workers and all other individuals with dignity and respect and to help CognitivZen in achieving these goals.

This statement reaffirms the Company's dedication to the principles of Equal Employment Opportunity and our expectation that all employees will lend their full support to furthering our success through implementation of these principles.

If any employee believes that he/she has been subjected to any form of prohibited discrimination or has otherwise been treated in any way that is inconsistent with this policy, then that employee should provide a written complaint either to the Disciplinary Committee, to his/her supervisor or to the Head of Human Resources. This complaint should be specific and should include the names of individuals involved and any witnesses. The Company will undertake a timely, thorough and effective investigation of the complaint. If the Company determines that prohibited discrimination has occurred, it will take appropriate remedial action. Appropriate action will be taken to deter any future discrimination. The Company will not retaliate against an employee for filing a complaint and will not knowingly permit retaliation by management or other employees.

➤ **Inclusive Environment:** We foster an inclusive environment where diversity is celebrated, valued, and

embraced.

- **Training and Development:** We offer training programs to enhance awareness and understanding of diversity and inclusion topics.
- **Recruitment and Hiring:** We are committed to hiring a diverse workforce, reflecting the communities we serve.
- **Employee Resource Groups:** We support employee-led resource groups to foster belonging and provide a platform for underrepresented voices.
- **Accountability:** We hold ourselves accountable for advancing diversity and inclusion goals, regularly reviewing our progress and seeking feedback from employees.
- **Continuous Improvement:** We are dedicated to continuously improving our diversity and inclusion efforts through ongoing evaluation and adaptation.

5.2 Hiring & Employment Policy

Employment Application:

CognitivZen relies upon the accuracy of information contained in the employment application and the accuracy of other data presented throughout the hiring process and employment. Any misrepresentations, falsifications, or material omissions in any of this information or data may result in exclusion from further consideration for employment or, if already hired, termination of employment.

Recruitment & Selection:

The selection and recruitment for employment is made on an open competitive basis in accordance with the Company's Business needs. Management or the Board of Directors shall make all senior leadership appointments. The applicant when successfully appointed shall be given an offer letter signed by the Head of Recruitment–Human Resources.

Employee(s) shall only be recruited when there is an adequate justification to fulfil the demand. All employees must upload a soft copy of their certificates and previous employment proofs as determined by the HR Department of the Company in the portal before commencement of their service. In case any original certificates/documents are to be retained by HR, for whatsoever reason, the same will be handed over to the human resource department for which an acknowledgement will be provided to the respective individual. The original certificates and documents will be returned to the employee as and when the formalities are over.

Hiring Interns

To foster and encourage young budding engineers who are in their final year, we encourage hiring them as interns with or without stipend. This is our social responsibility approach to invite eligible candidates witness a typical software development activity so that the candidates get first-hand experience about the industry and can choose their career path.

Education Qualification

- B. Tech / B.E and MTech / M.E or MCA / MBA in their final year.

Duration of the Internship

- **Duration:** Internship duration ranges from 3 to 6 months, varying by case.
- **Hours:** Interns must commit to a minimum of 20 work hours per week.
- **Assignment:** Interns will work in assigned departments or projects.
- **Attendance:** Regular attendance is mandatory and monitored by the reporting manager or guide. Absences due to unforeseen circumstances must be communicated to the reporting manager/HR.
- **Performance:** Unsatisfactory performance or unauthorized absences may result in termination of the internship.
- **Certificate:** Successful interns will receive a "Certificate of Completion" at the end of the internship.
- **Employment:** Completion of the internship does not guarantee employment.

Selection Process:

- In order to qualify, students must fulfill the following requirement.
- Intern must be enrolled or must have enrolled in a college/ University program.
- Students must have a good academic track record.
- Students must have good written and verbal communication skills.
- Students should be free from both civil and criminal charges.

5.3 Reference Checks

CognitivZen Technologies Pvt Ltd Company does Reference Checks for all new hires. Which includes

- Previous Employment verification

Any discrepancy in the Reference Checks with respect to period of employment, salary, providing falsified information, attitude and behaviour of the employee will result in terminating the employee.

Employees are responsible for providing all the right information to the Reference Checks team. Any discrepancy that needs correction and extra charges will have to be borne by the employee.

5.4 Personnel Records

Employee Personnel records are confidential and maintained by HR, disclosed only when legally required. To view their file, employees must submit a written request and review it in the presence of HR or an authorized manager. Copies are limited to documents signed by, addressed to, or submitted by the employee, unless otherwise required by law.

Employees must promptly update HR on any changes to personal details like name, address, contact number, marital status, dependents, beneficiaries, or emergency contacts to ensure accurate records and effective communication.

Every employee joining CognitivZen Technologies Pvt Ltd Company needs to furnish the following documents.

- Scanned Verified copies of Educational Qualification
- Certificates if any.
- The last 3 months Salary-slip as a proof of last drawn salary.
- Form 16
- Relieving/Experience letter from the previous employer.
- References.
- Copy of PAN & Aadhar Card

- Copy of passport

5.5 Probationary Period

The first 90 days of your active employment are considered as a probationary period. During this time, your performance on the job and your potential abilities will be evaluated to determine whether your job placement has been appropriate and if CognitivZen Company has met your expectations. Once you have completed the probationary period to the satisfaction of both yourself and CognitivZen Company, you will be considered a regular full-time employee.

Evaluation Criteria

The following factors will be considered before confirming an employee's probation:

Performance & Deliverables

- Completion of assigned tasks and responsibilities on time.
- Quality of work and ability to meet set objectives/KRAs.
- Feedback from reporting managers.

Attendance & Punctuality

- Consistent presence during working days.
- Adherence to working hours.
- No unauthorized leaves.

Leave and Work from Home (WFH) Policy during Probation

- **No leaves or WFH are permitted** during the probation period unless in case of emergencies, with prior approval.
- If the employee has taken any **leaves or WFH during probation**, the **number of days taken will be added to extend the probation period** accordingly.

Confirmation Process

Performance Review:

- A formal review will be conducted by the reporting manager and HR before the end of the probation period.

HR Evaluation:

- HR will verify attendance, leave records, and compliance with probation norms.

Extension (if required):

- In cases of performance concerns or policy non-compliance (e.g., leave or WFH taken), probation may be extended accordingly.
- An official communication will be sent regarding the extension period and expectations.

Confirmation Letter:

- On satisfactory completion, a **Probation Confirmation Letter** will be issued, confirming the employee's permanent status with the organization.

5.6 Performance Management & Evaluation

Performance reviews are important at CognitivZen. Employee performance review is initiated quarterly through CognitivZen HR. All employees are reviewed for their performance by their team members, peers and supervisors.

Annual Increments Employee Annual increment happens after the completion of their service anniversary,

based on their performance ratings for the year and recommendation by their reporting manager. Performance holds the key for success at CognitivZen.

Objective Company's objective is to better overall performance through recognition of individual's Contribution, bringing in accountability for individuals, promote teamwork, team values and Co-operation and bring in focus on company success as a whole. Excellent performance hence needs to be recognized and appropriately rewarded.

Simultaneously for non-performers areas for improvement shall have to be identified and necessary PIP (Performance Improvement Plan) is initiated.

Applicability This policy is applicable to all employees. Salary Increment is on a yearly basis from the date of joining in the Organization.

The following is the Appraisal cycle for all the employees working in the CognitivZen.

Q1	-	1 st April to 30 th June	-	Effective July
Q2	-	1 st July to 30 th September	-	Effective October
Q3	-	1 st October to 31 st December	-	Effective January
Q4	-	1 st January to 31 st March	-	Effective April

Note: Employees who join before the 15th of January, April, July, or October will be appraised in the same quarter. i.e., if an employee joins on the 10th of April, their appraisal will take place in Q4 (Same quarter).

Eligibility All CognitivZen employees are eligible for the increment policy based on the performance appraisals in the previous year. Employees should continue to maintain an average rating of above 3.0 in their previous 2 quarters.

Disbursement Increments are effective each year based on the date of joining.

Performance Bonus is compensation for the work performed above and beyond normal or expected duties. Since it is not easy to quantify whether an individual has gone above and beyond their expected duties, we use performance evaluations to determine this.

Since these evaluations are a combination of ratings provided by your team members, peers, and Managers, chances of getting this right are very high.

Bonus Payment:

Bonus payment will now be made **once a year** along with payroll for the month **of Employee Service Anniversary** to all eligible employees. The bonus will be calculated based on employee performance review rating for the year.

Any queries related to the rating and amount should be discussed with HR Head within a month of the payout. If you need any help in understanding this document, feel free to reach out to hr@cognitivzen.com and we shall do the needful.

5.7 Client Engagement & Conduct Guidelines

Client Interaction Guidelines

- Use client resources (facilities, equipment, internet, etc.) strictly for project-related purposes and only with client permission. Personal or unrelated company activities are not allowed.
- Maintain a clean and professional work area; do not leave confidential or proprietary information unattended.
- Adhere to all client rules, including security, access, and implementation protocols. It is your responsibility to understand and follow these policies.

Professional Conduct

- Maintain a respectful and professional attitude at all times—you're a guest at the client's site.
- Avoid making remarks about the client, their employees, or other vendors. Such comments can be misinterpreted and shared widely.
- If you hear inappropriate comments from colleagues, remind them to be cautious and professional.

Time Management

- Clients are billed for your time; use it wisely and appear engaged. Avoid frequent breaks, late arrivals, or early departures.
- Do not engage in unrelated reading or personal activities at the client site.
- Confirm work hours, overtime, and on-call expectations before starting an assignment.

Assignment Changes

- Do not agree to any changes in your role, tasks, or project scope without prior approval from your CognitivZen Company manager.
- If a client requests changes, accept the instructions respectfully and inform your manager immediately.
- Report any obstacles or issues affecting your work to your manager as soon as possible.

Project Delivery

- Commit only to tasks explicitly outlined in the project plan or approved by the project manager.
- Mixed or unclear expectations can lead to issues during reviews or delivery phases.

Conflict Handling

- Always remain calm and professional during conflicts or tense situations.
- Avoid confrontations. If a conflict arises, excuse yourself and report it to your manager.
- Keep disagreements with colleagues private and escalate unresolved issues appropriately.

Focus and Scope Control

- Manage your time effectively and remain focused on project goals.
- Any client requests outside the defined scope should be discussed with the project manager before proceeding, especially if it impacts project timelines or deliverables.

5.8 Professional Training & Development Policy

At CognitivZen, we value the continuous growth and development of our employees. This Training and Development Policy outlines the opportunities available for professional growth, the requirements for participation, and the guidelines for Certification reimbursement.

Training Opportunities and Requirements

Opportunities

- CognitivZen offers a variety of training programs to enhance the skills and knowledge of employees.
- Training opportunities may include in-house workshops, external seminars, online courses, conferences, and certifications relevant to employees' roles and career goals.

Requirements

- Participation in training programs is encouraged for all employees to support their professional development.
- Employees are expected to discuss their training needs and career aspirations with their managers during performance reviews or development discussions.
- Managers will work with employees to identify suitable training opportunities aligned with their career goals and the needs of the organization.
- Employees may be required to attend specific training sessions or workshops deemed necessary for their role or career advancement.

Professional Development Programs

- CognitivZen offers structured professional development programs to employees seeking career advancement opportunities.
- These programs may include mentorship programs, leadership development programs, rotational assignments, and specialized training tracks tailored to specific job roles or career paths within the organization.
- Participation in professional development programs is voluntary but highly encouraged for employees aspiring to grow within the company.

Certification Policy

Eligibility

- Full-time employees who have completed at least one year of continuous service with CognitivZen are eligible for Certification reimbursement.
- Employees must be in good standing and have satisfactory job performance to qualify for Certification reimbursement.

Certificate Support

- The organization will support certification programs that are essential for an employee's current project requirements or are aligned with organizational goals.
- All such support is subject to prior approval from the reporting manager and HR before enrolling in any courses or programs, based on relevance and business need.

Reimbursement Process

- Employees must submit a formal request for a Certification reimbursement along with proof of completion of the course and proof of payment.
- CognitivZen will reimburse a 50% percentage of the Certification fees upon successful completion of the course, subject to a maximum annual reimbursement limit of INR Rs. 15,000.
- Reimbursement percentages and maximum limits may vary depending on the relevance of the course to the employee's current role or future career within the company.

Conditions

- Certification reimbursement is contingent upon the employee achieving a passing grade (as defined by CognitivZen) in the course or program.
- Employees who receive Certification reimbursement are required to remain with CognitivZen for a specified period of 12 months after completing the course. If the employee leaves the company voluntarily before fulfilling this obligation, they may be required to repay the reimbursed amount on a prorated basis.

5.9 CognitivZen's Acknowledgement of Reward & Recognition for Excellence (CARE)

This reward is meant to recognize and encourage positive behaviour and attitude among employees, who contribute in the enhancement of productivity, efficiency and effectiveness in the workplace. The various categories of the reward are listed below. The relevant criteria may be either three or all.

CARE Program:

- **Recognition Criteria:** Employees will be recognized for outstanding performance, teamwork, leadership, innovation, and going the extra mile.
- **Types of Recognition:** Recognition can come in the form of verbal praise, written commendations, awards, bonuses, promotions, and more.
- **How Recognition Works:** Recognition can happen through team meetings, emails, or formal ceremonies.
- **Frequency of Recognition:** While formal recognition happens periodically, informal appreciation is encouraged daily.



Benefits of the CARE Program:

- **Boost Morale:** Recognizing employees boosts morale, motivation, and job satisfaction.
- **Retain Talent:** Appreciated employees are more likely to stay with the company.
- **Reinforce Values:** Recognizing behaviors that align with company values strengthens our culture.
- **Positive Environment:** A culture of recognition creates a positive and supportive workplace.

We encourage everyone to participate by nominating colleagues and celebrating each other's achievements. Let's build a culture of appreciation and excellence together!

6. EMPLOYEE POLICIES

6.1 Employment Categories

It is the intent of the Organization to provide the classification of employment categories so that employees understand their employment status and benefit eligibility. These classifications do not guarantee employment for any specified period of time. Both the employee and the Organization retain the right to terminate the employment relationship “at-will” at any time.

Each CognitivZen employee belongs to one of the following categories.

Probation

In the workplace, probation is a status assigned to new employees to evaluate their performance, behaviour, and compatibility. At CognitivZen, the probation period ranges from **3 to 6 months**.

- If the employee performs well, they are moved to **Permanent** status.
- If not, the probation may be extended, or employment may be terminated.
- If excess leave is taken during probation, the period will be extended accordingly.

Permanent

Permanent employees work full-time and are not limited by a project's completion or a predetermined end date.

- They are eligible for **full CognitivZen benefits**, subject to applicable terms.
- A **2-month notice period** applies to resignation employees and 2 weeks of notice period applies for termination employees.

Trainee

This designation is for **fresh graduates** entering the workforce for the first time.

- The **training period is 6 months**.
- Upon successful completion and based on performance, the employee is moved to **Permanent** status, along with **salary revision** and an updated designation.

Contract

Contract employees are hired for a **specific period** or to work on a **defined project or assignment**.

- Their tenure, compensation, and scope of work are defined in the **contract agreement**.
- They are **not eligible** for all benefits applicable to permanent employees, unless explicitly mentioned.
- **Notice period, renewal terms, and exit clauses** will follow the terms defined in the respective contract.

Intern

Interns are typically **students or recent graduates** engaged for a short-term learning experience within the organization.

- Internships may range from **1 to 6 months** or as mutually agreed.
- Interns work under supervision to gain industry exposure and **are not considered permanent or probationary staff**.
- They are **not eligible for regular employee benefits**, unless stated otherwise.
- An internship **certificate** may be provided upon successful completion.

6.2 Attendance and Punctuality

The objective of this policy is to lay down the rules pertaining to working hours and marking attendance. Employees are required to follow this policy as company places a high importance to punctuality and discipline.

Business Hours/Office Timings The standard company business hours are from 10:00 AM to 7:00 PM with 1 hour for breaks. Lunch can be taken between 1:00 PM and 3:30 PM. Your specific work hours may vary depending on your job nature, and your manager will communicate any adjustments to you. Additionally, we offer flexible timings, allowing you to discuss your preferred office hours with your manager and HR, as long as they don't affect client or team commitments.

Hours of Work The standard working hours are 40 hours per week, Monday to Friday. As a full-time employee, you are expected to work additional hours as and when reasonably necessary for the effective performance of your job or as business demands necessitate.

Marking of attendance

- Use access cards to mark attendance upon entry to the office; ensure records are maintained in CognitivZen HR.
- Aim to arrive at the office by 10:00 AM or at a time agreed with your Manager/HR, with a 15-minute grace period.
- Sign in and out using the HRMS Application in addition to access cards.
- Repeat lateness without prior notice may affect performance appraisals and lead to disciplinary measures.
- Manage workload to complete tasks within office hours; punctuality is encouraged.
- Unauthorized absences result in loss of pay ("NO WORK NO PAY" policy).

How to Regularize Your Attendance:

Navigate to Attendance Info page under Attendance Module => Click on Regularize => Select "From Time" and "To Time" => Enter the reason => Give Submit.

Permissions

- Arrive at work punctually each business day, including returning from meals or breaks.
- You are entitled to 2 out-time requests per month, each lasting up to 2 hours, without affecting vacation time.
- In case of absence, submit reasons and duration to your Reporting Manager and HR via CognitivZen HR

or email. If delayed unexpectedly, inform your supervisor immediately.

- Out-time requests must be approved by the reporting manager through CognitivZen HR.
- Notify your manager when leaving the office during working hours, except during lunch breaks, for emergency contact purposes.
- Maintain attendance and punctuality; habitual lateness is considered a serious breach of discipline.

Breaks It is important that you take the breaks which you are given. Breaks are important for your rest and wellbeing. If additional breaks to your lunch break are taken throughout the day, then the additional time must be made up either at the start or at the end of the day.

You are expected to attend work and organized meetings punctually at the required times. This is an integral part of reliability and professional conduct.

6.3 ID and Access Card Policy

- Cardholders are responsible for the proper use of their employee ID/access card.
- CognitivZen is not liable for consequences resulting from card misuse.
- The card may only be used by the person to whom it is issued.
- All employees must visibly wear ID/access cards while on duty or accessing company facilities.
- Employees forgetting their card must inform HR for attendance recording.
- Lost, stolen, or damaged cards must be reported to HR immediately; the cardholder bears responsibility for any charges incurred until reported.
- Cards are CognitivZen property and must be returned upon resignation or termination.
- HR may establish additional procedures as needed for policy implementation.
- Department Managers and supervisors enforce this policy, reporting violations to HR. Willful or habitual violators may face discipline.

6.4 Leave Policy

Leave calculation is done on yearly basis from the month of January - December.

Core Leaves 16 leaves are credited to an employee's account each year. The 12 Earned/Annual leaves are credited on a monthly basis of 1 leave per month, at the ending of each month and 4 Sick leaves are credited on a quarterly basis of 1 leave per quarter, at the beginning of each quarter. At the end of the calendar year, leave balance subject to a maximum of 5 days will be carried forward to the next year.

Encashment of Leave Encashment is possible in the following cases:

- If the core leave balance exceeds 5 days at the end of the calendar year, the leaves over and above 5 can be encashed.
- Encashment will be calculated based on the basic salary and credited to the salary effective month every year in January.
- During the employees under probation and the trainees are not entitled for leave encashment, if they leave the organization or their services are terminated by the organization.
- Sick leaves will lapse at the end of the calendar year.

Loss of Pay

- Any Loss of Pay (LOP) has to be approved by the supervisor and HR. In case, no leave is available to the employee's credit, LOPs will be sanctioned by the corresponding managers based on the number of leaves already availed by the employee vis-vis the project status on which the employee who wants to avail the LOP.

Employees who avails continuous LOP's for **5 or more days**, then the intervening **Saturday and Sunday** will also be counted as part of the LOP.

(Example: Monday to Friday, or Wednesday to Tuesday — both cases include the weekend as LOP days.)

Unplanned leaves

- Employees going on leave without prior approval/permission of the manager will be treated as unplanned leaves and hence would be made LOP (Loss of Pay).

Work From Home

Work-from-Home (WFH) policy to provide flexibility to our employees. Each employee is entitled to work from home for up to 2 days per month. This policy aims to promote work-life balance and enhance productivity.

Please note the following guidelines:

- Employees must obtain prior approval from their respective managers before opting for WFH.
- WFH days should be planned in advance and communicated to the manager and team members.
- Employees are expected to maintain regular communication with their team during WFH days and be available during working hours.
- Employees should ensure confidentiality and security of company data while working remotely.
- WFH is subject to operational requirements and may be revoked or adjusted in the same month based on business needs.

Leave Application Process

- All leaves have to be applied by using our HRMS application at least a week in advance, except for Sick Leaves or Emergencies.
- Any leave of 3 or more consecutive days requires a minimum of two weeks advance notice.
- Leave applications sent only to HR Department, without approval of the Reporting Manager, are not valid.

How to Apply Leave in GreytHR:

Login to GreytHR => Navigate to Leave => Click Leave Apply => Select Leave type from dropdown => Select "From Date" and "To Date" => Select Sessions => Enter the reason => Give Submit.

6.5 Employee Referral Bonus Policy (ERBP)

The Organization relies on accurate information provided in employment applications and throughout the hiring process. Any misrepresentations, falsifications, or omissions may lead to exclusion from employment consideration or termination if already hired. To ensure qualified and productive hires, the Organization checks all employment references. Written inquiries will receive responses confirming dates of employment, job titles, and positions held.

Process

- HR Department will announce positions requiring references, providing necessary guidelines.
- Employees must share referred resumes to HR via specified email with subject line and include referrer's

name, employee number, and position.

- If the referred resume is in HR databank, employees will be informed within 7 working days. If not, employees can inquire after 7 days.
- HR will keep referrer informed of candidate's status during selection process.

Referral Reward Payment process

- The referral reward will be 2 divisions, and the 1st division will be paid for the next payroll immediately following the confirmation of the referred candidate. (i.e., 3 months' Probation).
- The 2nd division is paid after the 5 months completion of the referred candidate.
- In case the referred candidate leaves the organization within twelve months span of time of his/her joining, the 2nd division of the reward shall be paid back from the employee who referred.
- All the employees are eligible to refer to the candidates for the position published for employee referrals. However, the top management employees working in HR Department and all the employees who are at manager level and above designations are not entitled to any Referral reward.

Reward Matrix

Level	Title	Reward upon Completion of Probation (3 Months)	Reward upon Completion of 5 months	Total Reward Amount
0 to 2 Years	Trainee Engineers	NA	NA	No Reward
3 to 5 Years	Software Engineers	Rs. 10,000	Rs. 10,000	Rs. 20,000
6 to 10 Years	Senior Software Engineers/ Lead Software Engineers	Rs. 20,000	Rs. 20,000	Rs. 40,000
11 Years & Above	Managers & Above	Rs. 25,000	Rs. 25,000	Rs. 50,000

6.6 Buddy Program

This program is intended to guide new employees in the early months of their employment with us on the day-to-day operations and company culture.

Purpose of the Buddy Program:

1. Help new employees feel comfortable and settle in
2. Teach them about our company culture and values
3. Support them in learning about their job

Aim of this program:

1. Reduce Onboarding time
2. Reduce Employee Turnover during Probation
3. Develop realistic job expectations, positive attitudes and job satisfaction.

Duration:

2 Months (All new joiners will have buddy support for 2 months from the date of joining)

Appointing a Buddy

- Must be from the same team or group
- Should hold the same or higher designation
- Should have solid experience at CognitivZen
- Must understand and embody company culture, policies, and values
- Should possess patience, communication, and interpersonal skills
- Must be willing and enthusiastic to take up the role

Responsibilities of a Buddy

- Guide the new hire on core business functions
- Explain policies, procedures, systems, and culture
- Help them understand our core values and code of conduct
- Familiarize them with roles and responsibilities
- Boost confidence and comfort
- Support goal achievement and positive work attitude
- Assist in contributing effectively to the organization

6.7 Service Anniversary Policy

Service anniversary recognition is important at CognitivZen, and we creatively recognize our employees milestones as mentioned in the table below.

- From the employee master we identify the list of employees having service anniversaries in a particular month.
- On the day when an employee completes a year, HR will publish the wishes to the employee, marking a copy to all employees.

6.8 Payroll Policy

Pay Structure

Gross pay is calculated by adding various eligible allowances to the Basic pay. The breakup of Gross pay into Basic pay and other various allowances is mentioned below:

- Gross Pay 100%
- PF 12% of the Basic Pay (min Rs. 1800) and 1% administration charges (Employee & Employer)
- Basic Pay 40% of the Fixed Pay
- HRA (House Rent Allowance) 40% of the Basic Pay (Claimed against rental receipts)
- LTA (Leave Travel Allowance) 8.33% of the Basic Pay (Proof of travel & Bills Mandatory)
- Conveyance Allowance 10% of the Fixed Pay (Claim against Bills)
- Medical Allowance 6% of the Fixed Pay (Claim against Medical expenditure bills)
- Other Allowance Fixed Pay - Sum of all the Basic pay and other various allowances

- Professional Tax – Up to Rs. 200

Pay Deductions

The law requires that the Organization make certain deductions from every employee's compensation. Applicable statutory deductions from gross pay are Provident Fund, Professional Tax, and Income Tax.

The Organization offers programs and benefits beyond those required by law. Eligible employees may voluntarily authorize deductions from their pay checks to cover the costs of participation in these programs. Employees who have questions concerning a deduction made from a pay check or how it was calculated can ask the Finance Department to assist in having the questions answered.

Pay slips

The pay date for employees is the last banking day of every month. The pay period covered is the 1st day of the month and till the last day of the month (Loss of pay will be calculated up to 25th day of the month). For example, monthly pay paid on December 31 should cover the pay period from the 1st day of the month and till the last day of the month. However, the LOP's taken till 25th of every month will be calculated for the salary. Any LOP's taken after 26th would be taken for calculations in the following month.

Pay-slips are sent via email to the employees from HRMS Application.

Administrative Pay Corrections

The organization takes all reasonable steps to assure that employees receive the correct amount of pay in each pay and that employees are paid promptly on the scheduled payday.

In the unlikely event that there is an error in the amount of pay, the employee should promptly bring the discrepancy to the attention of the organization so that corrections can be brought to the notice of HR within 15 days from the date of issue of payslip. Once underpayments are identified, they will be corrected in the next regular payroll.

Provident Fund & Pension

Employees get the benefits of Provident Fund, Pension and Insurance under the Schemes of the Employees Provident Funds Act of 1952, collectively referred to as the EPF Law, of India.

The Employees Provident Funds Scheme

Under this Scheme an employee and his employer contribute to Provident fund and its total accumulation is paid with interest to the employee upon ending his service by the [Employee Provident Fund Organization](#).

During service, advances (loans) from PF are made available to an employee for his certain needs.

6.9 Insurance Coverage – (Health & Term)

All of us should take health insurance according to our needs. Taking health insurance protects us from the sudden, unexpected costs of hospitalization (or other covered health events, like critical illnesses).

Each of us is exposed to various health hazards and a medical emergency can strike any one of us without any prior warning. Healthcare is increasingly expensive, with technological advances, new procedures and more effective medicines that have also driven up the costs of healthcare. While these high treatment expenses may be beyond the reach of many, taking the security of health insurance is much more affordable.

Insurance benefit covers the eligible employee, spouse & 2 kids for Group Medical Insurance, this benefit program of Insurance Coverage is fully paid by the employer only. Organization is facilitating the employees in coordination with Insurance vendor for Medical Insurance.

This policy is renewed on the 20th day of the financial calendar year i.e. 20th April. Premiums vary with the size of the family and coverage.

Medical insurance expenses are admissible only if hospitalizations are for a minimum period of 24 hours.

Kindly note that all the claim intimations should be intimated to us within 24 hours of the incident occurred.

In the event that you have any queries or face any difficulty, please contact the representative given below.

For Day-to-Day Queries and diseases coverage details

For the contact of insurance vendor, please contact HR.

For the reimbursement process and submission of the required documents please contact Insurance Vendor/ HR Team.

Kindly retain a photocopy of all documents that are being submitted to us for your records.

6.10 Official Holidays

The organization will grant public holidays to all employees as per the holiday list.

According to applicable restrictions, the organization will grant paid holiday time off to all employees.

If a recognized holiday falls during a scheduled vacation, the day is treated as a holiday and does not reduce the eligible vacation time earned.

6.11 Social Media Policy

This policy provides guidance for an employee on usage of social media, which should be broadly understood as the purpose of this policy to include blogs, wikis, micro blogs, message boards, chat rooms, electronic newsletters, online forums, social networking sites, and other sites and services that permit users to share information with others in a contemporaneous manner.

The following principles apply to professional use of social media on behalf of CognitivZen as well as Personal use of social media when referencing CognitivZen:

- Employees must adhere to Company's Code of Conduct, Employee Handbook, and other policies when using social media regarding CognitivZen.
- Understand the potential impact of their actions on personal and company image as information posted may remain in public.
- Management may monitor employee social media activity; use discretion in posting material not harmful to CognitivZen, its stakeholders, or employees.

- Prohibited conduct includes posting defamatory, pornographic, proprietary, harassing, or libelous content.
- Employees must not disclose confidential information; consult HR if unsure.
- Refer press inquiries or legal questions regarding social media to authorized spokespersons.
- Obtain permission from HR before referring to current/former employees, clients, vendors, or using third-party copyrights.
- Use official or HR-approved titles on LinkedIn.
- Social media use should not interfere with work responsibilities; personal use on company systems discouraged.
- Personal social media usage may result in disciplinary action; employees are personally liable for legal/financial consequences.
- After-hours online activity violating policies may lead to disciplinary action.
- Include disclaimer on work-related content posted after-hours.
- Separate CognitivZen-related social media accounts from personal ones if possible.
- Breach of policy may result in disciplinary action; management's decision is final.

6.12 Asset Policy

Introduction

This Asset Policy outlines the guidelines and procedures for the management, use, and protection of company assets by employees. Company assets include but are not limited to equipment, technology devices, vehicles, furniture, and intellectual property.

Ownership

All assets provided to employees by CognitivZen remain the property of the company. Employees are responsible for the proper care and use of these assets and must not dispose of, sell, or transfer them without proper authorization.

Authorized Use

Employees are authorized to use company assets solely for business purposes related to their roles and responsibilities. Any personal use of company assets must be minimal and approved by the appropriate supervisor or manager.

Maintenance and Care

It is the responsibility of employees to maintain and care for company assets in good working condition. Regular maintenance schedules and procedures must be followed to ensure the longevity and functionality of assets.

Security

Employees must take appropriate measures to safeguard company assets from loss, theft, damage, or unauthorized access. This includes securing physical assets in designated areas and adhering to password protection and security protocols for digital assets.

Reporting

Employees must promptly report any damage, loss, or malfunction of company assets to their supervisor or the designated asset management team at itsupport@cognitivzen.com. Failure to report such incidents may result in disciplinary action.

Return of Assets

Upon termination of employment or at the request of the company, employees are required to return all company assets in their possession. This includes physical equipment, technology devices, access cards, and any other company-owned items.

Compliance

All employees are expected to comply with this Asset Policy and any additional guidelines or procedures established by the company regarding the use and management of assets. Non-compliance may result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment.

6.13 IT Security Guidelines

Hardware & Software Access

- **Company-Provided Equipment's:** Laptop, Mouse, Headset etc....
- **Additional Resources** such as Software Licenses, Monitors (Will be provided upon Manager Approval)
- How to Request? email to itsupport@cognitivzen.com (CC your respective manager)

Network & Security Guidelines

- **Password Policy:** Use strong passwords (min. 12 characters)
- **Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA):** Enabled for Outlook
- **System Security:** Always lock your system when stepping away
- **Network Usage:**
 - Use LAN cables or office Wi-Fi only for work systems
 - Do not connect mobile devices to office Wi-Fi

Data Privacy & Compliance

To maintain a secure and compliant work environment, all employees must strictly adhere to the following data privacy and security protocols:

Confidential Data Handling

- Always store and share confidential data securely using company-approved tools.
- Access company or client data only for authorized business purposes.

Compliance with IT Policies

- Follow all company IT policies related to data security and privacy.
- Use only approved software and platforms for work-related tasks.

Email & Phishing Security

- Do not open attachments or links from unknown or suspicious sources.
- Immediately report phishing attempts to the IT team.

Device & Access Management

- Use only company-approved devices for official work.
- Lock your workstation when unattended and protect devices with strong passwords.
- Do not transfer data using personal emails, USBs, or unauthorized platforms.

Data Sharing & Storage

- Share files only via company-approved platforms (e.g., Google Workspace, OneDrive).
- Store sensitive information in designated secure systems only.

Document Disposal

- Dispose of sensitive printed or digital documents securely—shred or delete properly.

Incident Reporting

- Immediately report any data breaches, device loss, or suspicious activity to IT or HR.

Refer to All Information Security Policies in HRMS Portal.

6.14 Dress Code Policy

Objective

The Company recognizes the growing popularity of casual business dress and the positive effects of this shift to boost employee morale, improve quality, encourage more open communication and increased productivity, therefore, creating a more comfortable work environment. Therefore, casual business attire will be permitted on Fridays. The Company reserves the right to continue, extend, revise or revoke this policy at its discretion.

It is management's intent that work attire should complement an environment that reflects an efficient, orderly, and professionally operated organization. This policy is intended to define appropriate **"business attire"** during normal business operations and **"casual business attire"** on Fridays.

Note: Employees violating Dress code policy are subject to disciplinary action.

Guidelines for Dress Code

- Employees are required to adhere to a formal dress code during working days, consisting of collared shirts, formal pants, socks, and polished shoes for gentlemen, and western business suits or Indian formal wear for ladies.
- On weekends (Friday), a smart casual dress code is permitted, including collared T-shirts, jeans, slacks, and closed shoes for gentlemen, and T-shirts, jeans, sneakers, pants, or sandals for ladies.
- A professional appearance is essential when interacting with customers, clients, and suppliers, and employees should dress accordingly.
- Attire such as flip-flops, shorts, extremely high heels, party wear, halter tops, and excessive jewelry should be avoided, as they may distract or pose risks.
- Employees, unsure about dress code guidelines should seek clarification from their supervisor or the HR department.
- Non-compliance with the dress code may result in warnings or disciplinary action. No obnoxious clothing is entertained.

6.15 Clean Desk Policy

Employees are encouraged to keep their work area clean and in order. Eating or drinking in the work area is discouraged. CognitivZen is a smoke-free office environment. Employees should use designated smoking areas only. When in doubt employees should ask the HR manager.

7. EMPLOYEE CONDUCT

7.1 Conflicts of Interest

CognitivZen does not prevent its employees from engaging in lawful activities during non-business hours; however, each employee must ensure that his or her outside activities does not conflict or interfere with his or her responsibilities to the company. A conflict of interest occurs when an Employee's personal interest interferes, or is perceived to interfere, with the interests of the company. Each individual's situation is different, and it is not realistic to outline exactly what constitutes a conflict of interest in all possible circumstances. The following are several examples that are or could be considered a conflict of interest:

- Providing assistance to an organization that markets products or services in competition with CognitivZen's current or potential products and services.
- Simultaneously working for a competitor as an employee, a consultant, or as a member of its board of directors.
- Commercially marketing products or services in competition with CognitivZen's current or potential offerings.
- Performing outside work or soliciting such business while on CognitivZen premises, including while on CognitivZen customer sites or while on working hours. Use of CognitivZen equipment, telephones, materials, resources or proprietary information for outside work is also not permitted unless explicitly approved by a member of CognitivZen Executive Management.
- Having a material financial interest in any organization with which CognitivZen does business or competes, such organizations include suppliers, competitors, customers, distributors and CognitivZen business partners; or
- Providing CognitivZen's proprietary or confidential information to a competitor of CognitivZen unless such disclosure has been approved by an appropriate CognitivZen management, and a Nondisclosure Agreement is in place.

Each employee must disclose any transaction or relationship that reasonably could be expected to result in a conflict of interest to a member of the Compliance Committee.

7.2 Use of Personal Devices at Workplace

This policy outlines guidelines for the appropriate use of personal devices within CognitivZen's workplace. Applies to all employees, contractors, and visitors who use personal devices on company premises or to access company networks.

Permissible Use

- Personal devices allowed for work-related tasks only.
- Must comply with company data security measures.
- Users are responsible for adherence to laws, regulations, and company policies.

Prohibited Activities

- Unauthorized access to company networks or data.
- Downloading unauthorized software or files.

- Storing company-sensitive information without authorization.

Monitoring and Enforcement

- CognitivZen reserves the right to monitor personal device usage.
- Violations may result in disciplinary action, including termination.

7.3 Intellectual Property Rights and Ownership Policies

This policy outlines the ownership, protection, and management of intellectual property (IP) created by employees and contractors of CognitivZen.

- All IP created within the scope of employment or using company resources belongs to CognitivZen. Contractors must assign ownership of any IP developed for the company.
- Employees and contractors must safeguard company IP from unauthorized use or disclosure. Confidentiality agreements may be required for access to sensitive IP.
- Respect third-party IP rights and obtain necessary licenses or permissions for use. Unauthorized use of third-party IP is prohibited.
- Promptly disclose any potentially patentable inventions or valuable IP to the company. Contractors must also disclose IP created under their contracts.
- CognitivZen will take legal action to protect its IP rights. Violations may result in disciplinary action or termination.

7.4 Grievance Handling

Business organizations must have to establish an excellent working environment so that employee morale and performance would increase and ultimately organization should be able to achieve its goal. Employee grievances are one of the important factors that act as a barrier to establish an appropriate working environment.

Therefore, the management should be efficient in handling employee grievances and organization should have appropriate dispute resolution and grievance handling procedures.

- An employee can take recourse to various channels for getting any grievance redressed. Any issue or concern related to one's area of work may be escalated.
- Any employee may approach his/her manager, and the matter can be brought to the notice of the HR Department.

The respective managers & HR Department will aim to settle the grievance as quickly, fairly, and as near to the point of origin as possible.

7.5 CognitivZen Handshake & Separation Policy

Separation Policy

At CognitivZen Technologies, employee separation can occur through resignation, termination, retirement, or workforce restructuring. The company reserves the right to terminate employment at its discretion.

Probationary Employment

- Employees on probation may be terminated without notice.

- Permanent employment confirmation is subject to satisfactory performance.
- Probation may be extended based on performance feedback & managerial assessment.

Notice Period & Termination

- Permanent employees are required to serve a **2-month notice period** or pay in lieu.
- Employees receiving **3 written warnings** for poor performance may face termination without notice.
- Misconduct can lead to **immediate dismissal without notice**.

Examples of Misconduct

Includes, but not limited to:

- Misrepresentation, falsifying records, insubordination
- Harassment, abusive behavior, theft
- Unauthorized data sharing or use of company resources
- Alcohol/drug use at the workplace, absenteeism
- Breach of confidentiality or company policies

CognitivZen Handshake

On exit, employees must return all company property including laptops, ID cards, and documents. No data should be deleted or transferred. Disclosure or use of CognitivZen proprietary or client information post-exit is strictly prohibited. Any severance or dues may be withheld until all assets are returned.

Relieving & Exit Process

- Resignations must be submitted in writing to the manager and HR.
- Notice period starts from the date of managerial approval.
- **Leaves post-resignation** are treated as unpaid unless approved.
- Exit Checklist and return of all assets are mandatory for Full & Final Settlement.
- Final settlement and documents (Service Certificate, Tax Forms) will be issued after all clearances.
- The Service Certificate will be issued within 2 weeks from the employee's date of relieving.
- PF transfer and withdrawal must be initiated by the employee.

8. WORKPLACE PRACTICES

8.1 Open Door Policy (Suggestions, Feedback and Complaints)

We encourage employees to freely express their views in improving present process, practice, policy or complaint can share it to hr@cognitivzen.com and make CognitivZen the best place to work. All feedbacks and suggestions are kept confidential. We also have an option where you can give anonymous feedback /grievance at home below your login credential section in CognitivZen HR.

- CognitivZen maintains an open-door policy to facilitate communication between employees and management.
- Employees are encouraged to approach their supervisors, managers, or HR with any concerns, questions, or suggestions they may have.

- Management is committed to addressing employee concerns promptly and transparently.
- Retaliation against employees who utilize the open-door policy is strictly prohibited and will result in disciplinary action.

8.2 Communication and Reporting

Communication Channels and Expectations

Internal Communication Tools:

- Employees are encouraged to use company-provided communication tools for work-related discussions.
- Use of personal messaging apps for work purposes is discouraged to maintain data security and confidentiality.

Email Policies:

- Email should be used primarily for work-related communication.
- Employees are expected to adhere to professional etiquette when composing emails.
- Confidential information should not be shared over email unless encrypted.
- Use of company emails for personal correspondence is prohibited.

Reporting Concerns

Whistleblower Policies:

- CognitivZen is committed to maintaining a safe and ethical work environment.
- Employees are encouraged to report any misconduct, unethical behavior, or legal violations without fear of retaliation.
- Reports can be made anonymously through designated channels, such as a email address etc.
- All reports will be investigated promptly and impartially.

Reporting Misconduct:

- Employees should report any instances of misconduct, harassment, discrimination, or policy violations to their immediate supervisor, HR, or designated reporting authority.
- Reports should include detailed information about the incident, including dates, times, and witnesses if applicable.
- Confidentiality will be maintained to the extent possible during the investigation process.

9. ACKNOWLEDGEMENT AND AGREEMENT

I acknowledge that I have read the Employee Manual, and it replaces any and all prior verbal and written communications regarding CognitivZen's working conditions, HR policies & procedures, Information Security System, Data Security, Organization and Client data & information, Workplace ethics, Code of conduct Benefits, Security Inspection etc.

Since the information, policies, and benefits described herein are subject to change at any time, I acknowledge that revisions to the Employee Manual may occur, except to the Company's policy of employment-at-will.

I understand that all the details given in the Employee Manual are confidential and may not be distributed in any way nor discussed with anyone who is not an employee of our organization.

I have read and understand the contents and will act in accord with these policies and procedures as a condition of my employment with CognitivZen.

I understand that if I have questions or concerns at any time about the Employee Manual or the Standards of Conduct, I will consult the HR team.

I have gone through and understood the Employee Manual. I also understand that it is my responsibility to familiarize myself with the information in the Manual and keep myself informed as and when new information is distributed.

Employee Name Chitrakavi Lakshmi Anuhya

Employee Signature 

Date 24/02/2026